

US Patent & Trademark Office

Patent Public Search | Text View

United States Patent Application Publication

20250284295

Kind Code

A1

Publication Date

September 11, 2025

Inventor(s)

IWAZAKI; Noritsugu et al.

VEHICLE MANUFACTURING SYSTEM AND VEHICLE MANUFACTURING METHOD

Abstract

A vehicle manufacturing system according to this embodiment is a vehicle manufacturing system for performing control in such a way that a plurality of vehicles forming a platoon travel during a manufacturing process or a transporting process, the vehicle manufacturing system including: a computing unit configured to compute a control instruction value; a sensor provided to detect an inter-vehicle distance; determination unit for determining, based on the inter-vehicle distance, whether or not the platoon is disturbed; a transmitter configured to transmit, in a case where the platoon is not disturbed, a common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles; a communication apparatus that is provided in the vehicle and receives the control instruction value; and speed control unit for controlling the speed of the vehicle in accordance with the control instruction value.

Inventors: IWAZAKI; Noritsugu (Sunto-gun, JP), KANO; Takeshi (Seto-shi, JP), INOUE; Go (Gotenba-shi, JP), OKAMOTO; Yuki (Ebina-shi, JP), OHARA; Kento (Nisshin-shi, JP), TAKAHASHI; Satoshi (Yokohama-shi, JP)

Applicant: TOYOTA JIDOSHA KABUSHIKI KAISHA (Toyota-shi, JP)

Family ID: 94386549

Assignee: TOYOTA JIDOSHA KABUSHIKI KAISHA (Toyota-shi, JP)

Appl. No.: 19/028321

Filed: January 17, 2025

Foreign Application Priority Data

JP	2024-035598	Mar. 08, 2024
----	-------------	---------------

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: G05D1/695 (20240101); G05D107/70 (20240101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC G05D1/695 (20240101); G05D2107/70 (20240101)

Background/Summary

CROSS REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS

[0001] This application is based upon and claims the benefit of priority from Japanese patent application No. 2024-035598, filed on Mar. 8, 2024, the disclosure of which is incorporated herein in its entirety by reference.

BACKGROUND

[0002] The present disclosure relates to a vehicle manufacturing system and a vehicle manufacturing method.

[0003] Patent Literature 1 discloses a vehicle manufacturing system. A vehicle travels, by autonomous control or remote control, in a system for producing vehicles.

[0004] [Patent Literature 1] Published Japanese Translation of PCT International Publication for Patent Application, No. 2017-538619

SUMMARY

[0005] In a vehicle manufacturing factory, a plurality of vehicles are sequentially manufactured. In a case where a plurality of vehicles perform self-propelled transportation, a server or the like transmits control instruction values to the plurality of vehicles as radio signals. If the server individually obtains, for each of the vehicles, control instruction values and transmits these control instruction values to the respective vehicles, a communication load and a processing load increase.

[0006] An object of the present disclosure is to provide a vehicle manufacturing system and a vehicle manufacturing method capable of preventing a communication load and a processing load from increasing.

[0007] A vehicle manufacturing system according to the present disclosure is a vehicle manufacturing system for performing control in such a way that a plurality of vehicles forming a platoon travel during a manufacturing process or a transporting process, the vehicle manufacturing system including: computation unit for computing a control instruction value for controlling a speed of the vehicle; a sensor provided to detect an inter-vehicle distance, which is a distance between one of the plurality of vehicles and another adjacent one of the plurality of vehicles; determination unit for determining, based on the inter-vehicle distance, whether or not the platoon is disturbed; a transmitter configured to transmit, in a case where the platoon is not disturbed, a common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles; a communication apparatus that is provided in the vehicle and receives the control instruction value; and speed control unit for controlling the speed of the vehicle in accordance with the control instruction value.

[0008] In the above vehicle manufacturing system, the transmitter may transmit, in a case where the platoon is disturbed, individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles.

[0009] The above vehicle manufacturing system may further include address granting unit for granting, in a case where the platoon is not disturbed, a common address to the communication apparatus of each of the plurality of vehicles, and granting, in a case where the platoon is disturbed, individual addresses to the communication apparatuses of the plurality of respective vehicles.

[0010] In the above vehicle manufacturing system, the transmitter may transmit an individual control instruction value to the vehicle that has reached a predicted part where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary.

[0011] The above vehicle manufacturing system may include a camera configured to capture an image of any one of the vehicles in the platoon, in which the computation unit may compute the control instruction value based on a result of capturing the image in the camera.

[0012] In the above vehicle manufacturing system, the control instruction value may include a value indicating a speed or an acceleration of the vehicle.

[0013] A vehicle manufacturing method according to the present disclosure is a vehicle manufacturing method for performing control in such a way that a plurality of vehicles forming a platoon travel during a manufacturing process or a transporting process, the method including: computing a control instruction value for controlling a speed of the vehicle; detecting, based on a result of detection in a sensor, an inter-vehicle distance, which is a distance between one of the plurality of vehicles and another adjacent one of the plurality of vehicles; determining, based on the inter-vehicle distance, whether or not the platoon is disturbed; transmitting by a transmitter, when the platoon is not disturbed, a common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles; receiving the control instruction value by a communication apparatus provided in the vehicle; and controlling the speed of the vehicle in accordance with the control instruction value.

[0014] In the aforementioned vehicle manufacturing method, the transmitter may transmit, in a case where the platoon is disturbed, individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles.

[0015] The aforementioned vehicle manufacturing method may further include address granting unit for granting, in a case where the platoon is not disturbed, a common address to the communication apparatus of each of the plurality of vehicles, and granting, in a case where the platoon is disturbed, individual addresses to the communication apparatuses of the plurality of respective vehicles.

[0016] In the aforementioned vehicle manufacturing method, the transmitter may transmit an individual control instruction value to the vehicle that has reached a predicted part where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary.

[0017] The aforementioned vehicle manufacturing method may include capturing, by a camera, an image of any one of the vehicles in the platoon; and computing the control instruction value based on a result of capturing the image in the camera.

[0018] In the aforementioned vehicle manufacturing method, the control instruction value may include a value indicating a speed or an acceleration of the vehicle.

[0019] A vehicle manufacturing system according to the present disclosure is a vehicle manufacturing system for performing control in such a way that a plurality of vehicles forming a platoon travel during a manufacturing process or a transporting process, the vehicle manufacturing system including: computation unit for computing individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles in order to control a speed of the vehicle; a transmitter configured to transmit the individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles; a communication apparatus that is provided in the vehicle and receives the control instruction value; and speed control unit for controlling the speed of the vehicle in accordance with the control instruction value; communication status determination unit for determining a communication status; and control switching unit for switching control of the computation unit and control of the transmitter in accordance with a result of determining the communication status in such a way that the computation unit computes a common control instruction value for the plurality of vehicles and the transmitter transmits the common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles.

[0020] In the above vehicle manufacturing system, in a case where the communication status determination unit determines that the communication status is poor, the control switching unit may switch control of the computation unit and control of the transmitter in accordance with a result of determining the communication status in such a way that the computation unit computes a common control instruction value for the plurality of vehicles and the transmitter transmits the common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles.

[0021] In the above vehicle manufacturing system, in a case where the communication status

determination unit determines that the communication status is poor, the computation unit may compute the control instruction value so as to decrease the speed of the vehicle.

[0022] In the above vehicle manufacturing system, the transmitter may transmit an individual control instruction value to the vehicle that has reached a predicted part where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary.

[0023] A vehicle manufacturing method according to the present disclosure is a vehicle manufacturing method for performing control in such a way that a plurality of vehicles forming a platoon travel during a manufacturing process or a transporting process, the vehicle manufacturing method including: computing individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles to control at least one of a speed of the vehicle; transmitting, by a transmitter, the individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles; receiving the control instruction value by a communication apparatus provided in the vehicle; and controlling traveling of the vehicle in accordance with the control instruction value; determining a communication status; and switching control in accordance with a result of determining the communication status in such a way that a common control instruction value is computed for the plurality of vehicles and the common control instruction value is transmitted to the plurality of vehicles.

[0024] The aforementioned vehicle manufacturing method may include switching, in a case where it is determined that the communication status is poor, control in accordance with a result of determining the communication status in such a way that a common control instruction value is computed for the plurality of vehicles and the transmitter transmits the common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles.

[0025] The aforementioned vehicle manufacturing method may include computing, in a case where it is determined that the communication status is poor, the control instruction value so as to decrease the speed of the vehicle.

[0026] In the aforementioned vehicle manufacturing method, the transmitter may transmit an individual control instruction value to the vehicle that has reached a predicted part where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary.

[0027] According to the present disclosure, it is possible to provide a vehicle manufacturing system and a vehicle manufacturing method capable of preventing a communication load and a processing load from increasing.

[0028] The above and other objects, features and advantages of the present disclosure will become more fully understood from the detailed description given hereinbelow and the accompanying drawings.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF DRAWINGS

[0029] FIG. 1 is a schematic diagram showing a whole configuration of a vehicle manufacturing system according to a first embodiment;

[0030] FIG. 2 is a schematic diagram showing a part of the vehicle manufacturing system;

[0031] FIG. 3 is a block diagram showing a control system of the vehicle manufacturing system;

[0032] FIG. 4 is a flowchart showing a vehicle manufacturing method;

[0033] FIG. 5 is a block diagram showing a control system of a vehicle manufacturing system according to a second embodiment;

[0034] FIG. 6 is a flowchart showing a vehicle manufacturing method according to the second embodiment;

[0035] FIG. 7 is a diagram for describing travel control of a vehicle;

[0036] FIG. 8 is a control block diagram for describing a travel control example 1;

[0037] FIG. 9 is a flowchart for describing the travel control example 1;

[0038] FIG. **10** is a control block diagram for describing a travel control example 2; and [0039] FIG. **11** is a flowchart for describing the travel control example 2.

DESCRIPTION OF EMBODIMENTS

[0040] Embodiments of the present disclosure will now be described with reference to the drawings. However, the claimed disclosure is not limited to the following embodiments. Moreover, not all of the configurations described in the embodiments are essential as means for solving the problem. For the sake of clarity of the explanation, the following descriptions and drawings have been omitted and simplified as appropriate. In each drawing, the same elements have the same reference signs, and repeated descriptions have been omitted as appropriate.

First Embodiment

Vehicle Manufacturing System

[0041] With reference to FIGS. **1** and **2**, a vehicle manufacturing system **50** according to this embodiment will be described. FIG. **1** is a schematic diagram showing a configuration of the vehicle manufacturing system **50**. FIG. **2** is a diagram schematically showing two traveling vehicles **100**. FIG. **1** shows an XY orthogonal coordinate system for the sake of clarity of the explanation.

[0042] The vehicle manufacturing system (this may also be referred to as the system) **50** is used in a vehicle manufacturing factory where vehicles **100** are manufactured. The vehicle manufacturing system **50** is also used in a transport location where a transporting process such as transportation to a yard or shipment is carried out. As shown in FIG. **1**, the vehicle manufacturing system **50** includes a server **200**, a sensor **300**, and a robot **600**. The plurality of vehicles **100** are self-driving vehicles that can travel by themselves during a manufacturing process. The vehicle manufacturing system **50** performs control in such a way that the plurality of vehicles **100** perform travel in a form of a platoon (i.e. a formation or an alignment).

[0043] The sensor **300** includes a communication apparatus **330** that transmits or receives data to or from the server **200**. The server **200** includes a communication apparatus **230** that transmits or receives data to or from the sensor **300**. Further, as shown in FIG. **2**, the communication apparatus **230** has a function of transmitting or receiving data to or from the vehicle **100**. Further, the vehicle **100** includes a communication apparatus **130** that receives data from the server **200**. Each of the vehicles **100** includes the communication apparatus **130**.

[0044] The communication apparatus **130**, the communication apparatus **230**, and the communication apparatus **330** may each be general-purpose equipment such as a network hub or a router apparatus. The communication apparatus **130**, the communication apparatus **230**, and the communication apparatus **330** each use, for example, general-purpose wireless communication such as WiFi (registered trademark). In each of the communication apparatus **130**, the communication apparatus **230**, and the communication apparatus **330**, an address for specifying the communication partner is set. An address for communication is, for example, an Internet Protocol (IP) address.

[0045] Each of the vehicles **100** is a vehicle whose manufacturing has not yet been completed. As shown in FIG. **1**, the vehicle **100** travels along a traveling path TR set in advance. The manufacturing of the vehicle **100** is gradually done as it travels along the traveling path TR. Specifically, while the vehicle **100** travels along the traveling path, workers (not shown), a robot **600**, and the like perform assembling of parts, switch operations, welding, inspection, and so on. The work in each manufacturing process is thus performed. The work in each manufacturing process is performed in a predetermined order, whereby the vehicle **100** is manufactured.

[0046] A plurality of vehicles **100** travel in a form of a platoon. Specifically, the vehicles **100** travel at a constant speed in such a way that distances between vehicles are constant at a predetermined distance. Further, the plurality of vehicles **100** travel at the same speed. Further, the traveling path TR includes a straight-ahead area TR1 where a vehicle **100** travels straight ahead and a turning area TR2 where the vehicle **100** makes a turn. In the straight-ahead area TR1, the traveling path TR has

a linear shape.

[0047] The turning area TR2 is a place where the vehicle **100** changes its traveling direction. In the turning area TR2, the vehicle **100** makes a U-turn. In the turning area TR2, for example, the traveling path TR has an arcuate shape having a predetermined radius of curvature. In the turning area TR2, the traveling path TR is a semicircle. The turning area TR2 is provided in each end of the straight-ahead area TR1. For example, after traveling through the straight-ahead area TR1 in the +X direction, the vehicle **100** reaches the turning area TR2. After the vehicle **100** makes a turn by **180** degrees in the turning area TR2, the vehicle **100** travels through the straight-ahead area TR1 in the -X direction. On the other hand, after the vehicle **100** travels through the straight-ahead area TR1 in the -X direction, the vehicle **100** reaches the turning area TR2. After the vehicle **100** makes a turn by **180** degrees in the turning area TR2, the vehicle **100** travels through the straight-ahead area TR1 in the +X direction. In this manner, the manufacturing of the vehicle **100** is gradually done as it alternately passes through the straight-ahead area TR1 and the turning area TR2.

[0048] Further, the turning area TR2 is a predicted part P2 where it is expected that inter-vehicle distances will vary. In a case where, for example, the vehicle **100** is controlled so as to decelerate at a time when the vehicle **100** makes a turn, inter-vehicle distances between this vehicle **100** and vehicles traveling before and after this vehicle **100** vary. Therefore, the turning area TR2 is a predicted part P2 where it is expected that inter-vehicle distances will vary.

[0049] Further, a predicted part P1 where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary is also set in a part of the straight-ahead area TR1 as well. The predicted part P1 is, for example, a part where a force in the front-back direction is applied due to the presence of a slope, STOP&GO assembly points, or a manufacturing process. The slope is, for example, an uphill or a downhill. In a slope, the vehicle **100** may be accelerated or decelerated due to the gravity. Accordingly, the slope is the predicted part P1 where it is expected that inter-vehicle distances will vary.

[0050] The STOP&GO assembly points are points where the vehicle **100** temporarily stops. For example, in a case where the robot **600** performs welding or assembling, the vehicle **100** stops. More specifically, the vehicle **100** stops when it reaches an area where the robot **600** can move. Then, in the state in which the vehicle **100** stops, the robot **600** perform an assembling operation or a welding operation. Since the vehicle **100** temporarily stops, inter-vehicle distances vary. Accordingly, each of the STOP&GO assembly points is the predicted part P1 where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary.

[0051] The parts where a force is applied in the front-back direction in the manufacturing process are, for example, working places where a worker presses elements against a vehicle from the front or rear direction to assemble these elements. When the worker pushes elements in the front-back direction to assemble these elements, the vehicle **100** is accelerated or decelerated. The predicted part P1 and the predicted part P2 are associated, for example, in map information of a factory stored in the server **200**. For example, the server **200** stores map information in which coordinates indicating the predicted parts P1 and P2 are set. Control in the predicted parts P1 and P2 will be described later.

[0052] The sensor **300** is a camera that captures an image of the vehicle **100** which is moving or is stopped. The sensor **300** captures an image of one or a plurality of vehicles **100**. The sensor **300** is provided to detect inter-vehicle distances. The server **200** is able to detect the position of the vehicle **100** in the factory based on the image captured by the sensor **300**. The sensor **300** is installed, for example, on a wall surface, a support column, the ceiling or the like of the factory, and captures an image of the vehicle **100** from an oblique upward angle. The sensor **300** captures an image at an angle of view which includes two or more vehicles **100** that form a platoon. The sensor **300** may be installed at a height the same as that of the vehicles **100** and capture images of two or more vehicles **100** from a side direction thereof.

[0053] The communication apparatus **330** transmits the image captured by the sensor **300** to the server **200**. The communication apparatus **330** may transmit, besides the captured image,

information obtained from the captured image to the server **200**. That is, the communication apparatus **330** transmits a result of detection detected in the sensor **300**. Note that the communication apparatus **330** may be built in the sensor **300** or may be separated from the sensor **300**. Further, the communication apparatus **330** may be shared among a plurality of sensors **300**. That is, in a case where the plurality of sensors **300** are installed, one communication apparatus **330** may transmit data to the server **200**.

[0054] As described above, after the sensor **300** captures an image of the vehicle **100**, the communication apparatus **330** transmits the captured image and the like to the server **200**. The communication apparatus **230** receives data of the captured image from the sensor **300**. The server **200** performs predetermined image processing on the image captured by the sensor **300**, whereby it is possible to specify inter-vehicle distances. For example, the server **200** calculates inter-vehicle distances **D1-D4**, etc. of a plurality of vehicles **100** forming a platoon. The number of vehicles forming a platoon is not particularly limited and may be any number that is equal to or greater than three.

[0055] Further, the sensor **300** for detecting inter-vehicle distances is not limited to a camera. A sensor for detecting inter-vehicle distances may be various kinds of sensors such as an RGB camera, a far-infrared camera, or a LiDAR. The sensor **300** is not limited to an optical sensor, and may instead be a radar. As a matter of course, two or more sensors **300** may be installed, or two or more sensors **300** may be used in combination with each other. For example, the sensor **300** may include a LiDAR and a camera.

[0056] The communication apparatus **330** transmits a result of the detection to the server **200**. As described above, the result of the detection transmitted from the sensor **300** may be a captured image or may be information extracted from the image. In a case where, for example, the sensor **300** has an image processing function, the sensor **300** transmits information extracted by image processing to the server **200**.

[0057] Further, as shown in FIG. 2, the sensor **300** may be mounted on the vehicle **100**. The sensor **300** is, for example, an in-vehicle camera, a LiDAR, a radar, or the like. In a case where the sensor **300** is an in-vehicle camera, the sensor **300** captures an image of a vehicle **100** in front (this vehicle may be referred to as a front vehicle). In a case where the sensor **300** is an in-vehicle LiDAR, the sensor **300** measures a distance from the vehicle **100** to the front vehicle **100**. The communication apparatus **130** transmits the image and a result of the measurement to the server **200**.

[0058] The server **200** controls a vehicle **100** in such a way that the vehicle **100** moves along the traveling path TR. Further, the server **200** controls a plurality of vehicles **100** in such a way that the vehicles **100** perform platoon traveling. For example, the vehicles **100** travel along the traveling path TR in one line. The server **200** transmits a control signal to each vehicle **100** by the communication apparatus **230**.

[0059] Hereinafter, with reference to FIG. 3, a control system of the vehicle manufacturing system **50** will be described. FIG. 3 is a block diagram showing the control system of the vehicle manufacturing system **50**. FIG. 3 is a schematic diagram for describing communication processing in the vehicle manufacturing system **50**. While a single vehicle **100** and a single sensor **300** are shown in FIG. 3, a plurality of vehicles **100** and a plurality of sensors **300** are actually provided, as shown in FIG. 1.

[0060] The server **200** includes the communication apparatus **230**, a position calculation unit **252**, a computing unit **253**, an inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254**, a determination unit **255**, an address granting unit **256**, and an address management unit **257**. The vehicle **100** includes a vehicle control unit **115**, actuators **120**, and the communication apparatus **130**. The sensor **300** includes the communication apparatus **330**. Note that the server **200** is not limited to a physically single apparatus and a plurality of servers **200** may instead be provided in a distributed manner. For example, a database and so on may be a storage device, a cloud server, or the like that is provided separately from the processor.

[0061] While a configuration in which the position calculation unit **252**, the computing unit **253**, the inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254**, the determination unit **255**, the address granting unit **256**, and the address management unit **257** are mounted on the server **200** will be described in the following description, the position calculation unit **252**, the computing unit **253**, the inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254**, or the determination unit **255** may instead be mounted on the sensor **300** or the vehicle **100**. That is, the processing in the computing unit **253**, the position calculation unit **252**, the inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254**, and the determination unit **255** may be performed in the vehicle **100** or the sensor **300**.

[0062] The position calculation unit **252** calculates position information indicating the position and the orientation of the vehicle based on the captured image. For example, the position calculation unit **252** may obtain XYZ global coordinates or an orientation in a map of the factory. The position calculation unit **252** specifies each of positions of vehicles **100** on the map indicated in the map information. At least a part of the processing in the position calculation unit **252** may be performed in the sensor **300**. For example, the sensor **300** may include a processor or the like that performs image processing. In this case, position information indicating the position and the like of the vehicle **100** is transmitted from the communication apparatus **330** to the server **200**.

[0063] The position of the vehicle **100** and the orientation of the vehicle **100** may be estimated using the captured image acquired by the sensor **300** provided in a place other than the place where the vehicle **100** is located. The position of the vehicle **100** can be acquired by calculating coordinates of measurement points of the mobile body in an image coordinate system by using, for example, the outline of the vehicle **100** detected from the captured image, and converting the calculated coordinates into coordinates in a global coordinate system. The orientation of the vehicle **100** can be estimated based on, for example, a direction of a moving vector of the mobile body calculated from changes in positions of feature points of the mobile body between frames of the captured image using an optical flow method. The orientation of the vehicle **100** may be calculated using, for example, a result of output of a yaw rate sensor or the like mounted on the vehicle **100**.

[0064] The outline of the vehicle **100** included in the captured image can be detected, for example, by inputting the captured image to the detection model that uses artificial intelligence. The detection model may be, for example, a learned machine learning model learned so as to implement one of semantic segmentation or instance segmentation. This machine learning model may be, for example, convolutional neural network (hereinafter, CNN) learned by supervised learning using a learning dataset. The learning dataset includes, for example, a plurality of training images including the mobile body, and a ground-truth label indicating whether each area in the training image is an area indicating a mobile body or an area indicating a part other than the mobile body. When CNN learning is performed, parameters of the CNN are preferably updated in such a way that the error between the result of the output by the detection model and the ground-truth label is reduced by a back propagation method.

[0065] The computing unit **253** computes control instruction values for controlling the vehicle **100**. The computing unit **253** calculates control instruction values based on the position of the vehicle **100**. The computing unit **253** sends control instructions in such a way that the vehicle **100** moves along the traveling path TR. The control instruction values here may include a speed instruction value for controlling the speed of the vehicle and a steering angle instruction value for controlling a steering angle of the vehicle. The speed instruction value may be, for example, information indicating a speed, an acceleration, or the like of the vehicle **100**. The steering angle instruction value is information indicating a steering angle or the like of the vehicle **100**. The computing unit **253** generates control instruction values regarding the movement of the vehicle **100**. In this manner, the computing unit **253** creates control instructions regarding the movement of the vehicle **100**.

[0066] The communication apparatus **230** includes a receiver **231** and a transmitter **232**. The receiver **231** receives various kinds of signals, data, or the like from the sensor **300** and the vehicle **100**. The receiver **231** receives, for example, data indicating a result of detection by the sensor **300**.

Note that the data received from the sensor **300** may be image data or may be data extracted from the image data.

[0067] The transmitter **232** transmits various kinds of signals, data, or the like to the sensor **300** and the vehicle **100**. The transmitter **232** transmits, for example, control instruction values to the vehicle **100**. As a matter of course, the server **200** may transmit or receive data other than those stated above. As communication in the receiver **231** and the transmitter **232**, processing according to a general-purpose communication standard such as WiFi (registered trademark) may be used.

[0068] The communication apparatus **130** of the vehicle **100** is wireless terminal equipment for enabling wireless communication with the server **200**. An Internet Protocol (IP) address or the like is set in the communication apparatus **130**. After the communication apparatus **130** of the vehicle **100** receives control instruction values, the vehicle **100** moves in accordance with the control instruction values. The actuators **120** include a wheel motor for driving wheels, a steering motor for controlling the steering angle, a brake for stopping the vehicle, and so on. The vehicle control unit **115** generates control signals to control the actuators **120** in accordance with a control instruction. The vehicle control unit **115** may be composed of an Electronic Control Unit (ECU). Accordingly, the vehicle **100** can move along the traveling path TR.

[0069] The address granting unit **256** grants an address for communication to each vehicle **100** and the communication apparatus **130** of this vehicle **100**. For example, before the vehicle **100** starts traveling along the traveling path TR by itself, the address granting unit **256** grants an address to the communication apparatus **130**. Alternatively, an address may be associated with an ID of the vehicle **100**. Further, the address granting unit **256** grants an address to the communication apparatus **130** or the vehicle **100** in such a way that the traveling order and the address can be associated with each other. As will be described later, in a case where a platoon is not disturbed (i.e., not in disorder), the address granting unit **256** may grant a common address to the communication apparatus **130** of each of the plurality of vehicles. On the other hand, in a case where a platoon is disturbed (i.e., in disorder), the address granting unit **256** may grant individual addresses to the communication apparatuses **130** of the plurality of respective vehicles. The address granting unit **256** may grant the address before the start of production through self-propelled transportation or every time a control mode is switched.

[0070] The address management unit **257** manages addresses for communication in the entire factory. The address management unit **257** manages, for each address, whether it is being used or not being used. For example, the address management unit **257** includes a database for managing addresses. The address management unit **257** manages addresses of vehicles **100** which are carrying out self-propelled transportation as addresses that are being used. Then, for each of vehicles **100** that have already been manufactured, a flag indicating that the address is not being used is set. Accordingly, the addresses that are being used are changed to addresses that are not being used. The address management unit **257** may reuse the address that is no longer in use to control the next vehicle **100**.

[0071] The inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254** calculates inter-vehicle distances based on a result of detection by the sensor **300**. For example, the inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254** performs image processing on the image of the vehicle **100** captured by the sensor **300** to thereby calculate the inter-vehicle distances. The inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254** may calculate the inter-vehicle distances based on position information. Alternatively, the inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254** may calculate the inter-vehicle distances from a result of measurement by LiDAR or the like mounted on the vehicle **100**.

[0072] The determination unit **255** determines whether or not the platoon is disturbed based on the inter-vehicle distances. For example, for each of the vehicles **100**, inter-vehicle distances between each of the vehicles **100** and vehicles **100** in front and behind each of the vehicles **100** are calculated. The determination unit **255** determines whether or not the platoon is disturbed by comparing a plurality of inter-vehicle distances. For example, as shown in FIG. 1, the inter-vehicle

distance calculation unit **254** calculates inter-vehicle distances **D1-D3** between a plurality of vehicles **100** forming a platoon. The determination unit **255** detects whether or not the platoon is disturbed based on the calculated inter-vehicle distances **D1-D3**.

[0073] For example, a reference range indicating a reference distance is set in the determination unit **255**. Then, in a case where each of the inter-vehicle distances **D1-D3** is in the reference range, the determination unit **255** determines that the platoon is not disturbed. In a case where one of the inter-vehicle distances **D1-D3** is outside the reference range, the determination unit **255** determines that the platoon is disturbed. Alternatively, the inter-vehicle distances **D1-D3** are compared, and the determination unit **255** makes a determination based on a result of the comparison. For example, the determination unit **255** obtains a difference value of any two inter-vehicle distances. When the difference value is equal to or smaller than a predetermined value, the determination unit **255** determines that the platoon is not disturbed. In a case where the difference value has exceeded the predetermined value, the determination unit **255** determines that the platoon is disturbed.

[0074] The server **200** switches a group control and an individual control in a case where the server **200** transmits control instruction values to a plurality of vehicles **100**. In the group control, the server **200** transmits a common control instruction value to two or more vehicles **100** forming a group. Specifically, the plurality of vehicles **100** forming a platoon in one line belong to one group. The server **200** transmits the same control instruction value to two or more vehicles **100** that belong to one group. In the individual control, individual control instruction values are transmitted to the respective vehicles **100**.

[0075] After the communication apparatus **130** receives the control instruction value, the vehicle control unit **115** generates a control signal for controlling the actuators **120** in accordance with the control instruction value. For example, the vehicle control unit **115** controls a wheel motor or the like in such a way that the speed or the acceleration indicated by the control instruction value is achieved.

[0076] For example, the determination unit **255** determines that the platoon is not disturbed in the straight-ahead area **TR1**. In this case, the computing unit **253** creates a common control instruction value for the plurality of vehicles **100** in the platoon. In a case where a group control is performed, the computing unit **253** creates the same speed instruction value for a plurality of vehicles **100** aligned in one line. Then, the transmitter **232** transmits the common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles **100**. Therefore, the plurality of vehicles **100** that belong to one group can travel at the same speed.

[0077] Accordingly, it is possible to prevent the computing load and the communication load in the server **200** from increasing. For example, a control instruction value such as the speed or the acceleration is commonly used among a plurality of vehicles **100**. Accordingly, in the server **200**, it is not necessary to perform processing for obtaining the control instruction value for each of the vehicles **100**. For example, the computing unit **253** obtains a control instruction value for the leading vehicle **100** in the platoon. Then, the transmitter **232** transmits this control instruction value to the leading vehicle **100** and the following vehicles **100** through multicast. The transmitter **232** is able to transmit the control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles **100** through multicast. Accordingly, it is possible to prevent the communication load from increasing.

[0078] Assume that the determination unit **255** determines that the platoon is disturbed in the straight-ahead area **TR1**. In this case, the computing unit **253** creates individual control instruction values for the plurality of respective vehicles **100**. For example, the computing unit **253** creates different speed instruction values for the plurality of vehicles **100** as individual control. Then, the transmitter **232** transmits the individual control instruction values to the plurality of respective vehicles **100**. Therefore, the plurality of vehicles **100** are able to travel at different speeds.

[0079] According to the above configuration, it is possible to resolve disturbance of the platoon. In a case where an inter-vehicle distance has become greater than a predetermined value, the determination unit **255** determines that the platoon is disturbed. Then, the computing unit **253**

switches the group control to the individual control. For each vehicle **100** whose inter-vehicle distance from the front vehicle has become great, the computing unit **253** creates a control instruction value that makes the speed of this vehicle **100** higher than that of the front vehicle. That is, the computing unit **253** creates a control instruction value so as to accelerate the vehicle **100**. The computing unit **253** computes, based on the inter-vehicle distance, control instruction values specific to the respective vehicles **100**. The transmitter **232** transmits the control instruction values to the respective vehicles **100** through unicast. In this case, the following vehicle **100** approaches the front vehicle. Then, after the inter-vehicle distance has decreased to a predetermined value, the server **200** switches the individual control to the group control.

[0080] On the other hand, for each vehicle **100** whose inter-vehicle distance from the front vehicle has become small, the computing unit **253** creates a control instruction value that makes the speed of this vehicle **100** lower than that of the front vehicle. That is, the computing unit **253** creates a control instruction value so as to decelerate the vehicle **100**. In this case, the following vehicle **100** is away from the front vehicle. Then, after the inter-vehicle distance has increased to a predetermined value, the server **200** switches the individual control to the group control. Accordingly, it is possible to prevent the inter-vehicle distance from varying. Note that the speed instruction value for controlling the speed may be a speed value or an acceleration value.

[0081] According to the above configuration, even in a case where a platoon is disturbed, it is possible to resolve disturbance of the platoon. That is, a plurality of vehicles **100** perform platoon traveling at predetermined intervals.

[0082] Accordingly, it is possible to manufacture the vehicles **100** more safely and more efficiently, whereby productivity may be improved.

[0083] In the group control, the server **200** may manage a common address as addresses of the plurality of vehicles **100**. It is assumed, for example, that an IP address is assigned to radio equipment of each of the vehicles **100** as a destination address. It is further assumed that the server **200** can rewrite the IP addresses. That is, the server **200** manages IP addresses in the factory on a database. Then, the server **200** manages whether each IP address is being used or unused.

[0084] In the group control, the address granting unit **256** grants a common IP address to the plurality of vehicles **100**. The same IP address is assigned to the plurality of vehicles **100**, whereby the server **200** is able to easily perform a group control of the plurality of vehicles **100**. In the group control, the address granting unit **256** grants a common address to a plurality of vehicles **100** which belong to one group. The transmitter **232** transmits a common control instruction value to one IP address, which is a destination address.

[0085] In a case where the group control and the individual control are switched, the server **200** transmits a signal for rewriting the IP address to the vehicle **100**. When the control is switched to the group control, the IP address is rewritten in such a way that the communication apparatuses **130** of the respective vehicles **100** have a common address. When the control is switched to the individual control, the IP address is rewritten in such a way that the communication apparatus **130** of the vehicle **100** have an individual address. Then, the communication apparatus **130** transmits, to the server **200**, a signal indicating that the IP address has been rewritten. Upon receiving the signal from the communication apparatus **130**, the server **200** rewrites the data in the database so as to manage the IP address.

[0086] In the predicted parts P1 and P2, the server **200** may switch the control mode to the individual control. The transmitter **232** may transmit individual control instruction values to respective vehicles **100** that have reached the predicted parts P1 and P2 where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary. At a timing when the vehicles **100** enter the predicted parts P1 and P2, the server **200** switches the group control to the individual control. In the predicted parts P1 and P2, the server **200** transmits the individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles **100**. The vehicles **100** at the predicted parts P1 and P2 travel at their individual vehicle speeds. Therefore, each of the vehicles **100** may travel at an appropriate speed.

[0087] Further, at a timing when a vehicle **100** exits the predicted parts P1 and P2, the server **200** switches the individual control to the group control. Accordingly, the control mode of vehicles **100** other than those in the predicted parts P1 and P2 is switched to the group control. The server **200** transmits the common control instruction value to a plurality of vehicles **100** traveling in parts other than the predicted parts P1 and P2. Accordingly, it is possible to prevent the communication load from increasing.

[0088] While an example in which the control mode of controlling the speed instruction value regarding the speed is switched from the group control to the individual control has been described in the aforementioned description, a control mode of controlling the steering angle instruction value regarding the steering angle may instead be switched from the group control to the individual control. For example, in the straight-ahead area TR1, the server **200** transmits a common steering angle to a plurality of vehicles **100** which belong to one group as the steering angle instruction value.

[0089] Further, the sensor **300** may include a camera that captures an image of one of vehicles in a platoon. Accordingly, it is possible to appropriately detect each of the inter-vehicle distances D1-D3 of the plurality of vehicles **100**. Then, the computing unit **253** computes a control instruction value based on a result of capturing images in a camera. For example, the computing unit **253** calculates, by image processing, the position of the vehicle **100** and the inter-vehicle distances. The computing unit **253** obtains a control instruction value for the leading vehicle **100**. Then, in the group control, a common control instruction value is transmitted to the vehicles **100** in the group including the leading vehicle **100**. Accordingly, it is possible to prevent the communication load from increasing and to cause the vehicles **100** in the platoon to travel with a high accuracy. As a matter of course, the vehicle **100** whose image is captured by the sensor **300** is not limited to the leading vehicle **100**, and an image of the second vehicle **100** or the following vehicle **100** may instead be captured. Furthermore, the sensor **300** may capture images of two or more vehicles **100**.

[0090] FIG. **4** is a flowchart showing a vehicle manufacturing method according to this embodiment. With reference to FIG. **4**, the vehicle manufacturing method will be described. It is assumed, as described above, that a plurality of vehicles **100** forming a platoon are traveling along a traveling path TR. First, the server **200** sets in advance, for each of the vehicles **100**, an IP address for unicast and an IP address for multicast (S11). Accordingly, two addresses are set in a communication apparatus **130** of one vehicle **100**. The IP address for multicast is common among the plurality of vehicles **100**. The IP address for unicast is individually set in each of the plurality of vehicles **100**.

[0091] The sensor **300** detects a vehicle **100** (S12). In a case where the sensor **300** is a camera, the sensor **300** captures an image of the vehicle **100**. Next, the inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254** calculates inter-vehicle distances based on a result of detection by the sensor **300** (S13). In this example, the inter-vehicle distance calculation unit **254** performs image processing or the like to thereby calculate inter-vehicle distances between a plurality of vehicles **100** forming a platoon.

[0092] Next, the determination unit **255** determines, based on the inter-vehicle distances, whether or not the platoon is disturbed (S14). For example, the determination unit **255** determines whether or not the platoon is disturbed by comparing the inter-vehicle distances with a threshold.

Alternatively, the determination unit **255** determines whether or not the platoon is disturbed by comparing one inter-vehicle distance with another inter-vehicle distance.

[0093] In a case where the platoon is not disturbed (NO in S14), the computing unit **253** computes a common control instruction value for the plurality of vehicles **100** (S15). For example, the computing unit **253** computes, based on the position of each vehicle **100** with respect to the traveling path TR, a control instruction value for the group control. The control instruction value includes an instruction value regarding the speed. Then, the transmitter **232** transmits the control instruction value to the IP address for multicast (S16). In this example, the transmitter **232** transmits the same control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles **100** all at the same time.

The vehicle control unit **115** performs control in such a way that the plurality of vehicles **100** travel at the speed or the acceleration indicated by the common control instruction value.

[0094] In a case where the platoon is disturbed (YES in **S14**), the computing unit **253** computes individual control instruction values for a plurality of respective vehicles **100** (**S17**). For example, the computing unit **253** computes, based on the position of each of the vehicles **100** in the traveling path TR, control instruction values for individual control. Then, the transmitter **232** individually transmits the control instruction values to the IP addresses for unicast (**S18**). In this example, the transmitter **232** sequentially transmits different control instruction values to the plurality of respective vehicles **100**. The vehicle control unit **115** performs control in such a way that the respective vehicles **100** travel at the speed or the acceleration indicated by the individual control instruction values.

[0095] As described above, in a case where the platoon is not disturbed, the server **200** transmits a common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles **100**. Accordingly, it is possible to prevent computing and communication loads from increasing. Further, in a case where the platoon is disturbed, the server **200** switches the group control to the individual control. Then, the computing unit **253** computes the individual control instruction values and transmits the individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles **100**. Accordingly, it is possible to resolve disturbance of the platoon, whereby it is possible to perform stable control.

[0096] Further, in the predicted parts P1 and P2 where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary, the server **200** may switch the control mode of vehicles **100** to the individual control. For example, at a timing when vehicles **100** enter the predicted parts P1 and P2, the server **200** switches the control mode of these vehicles **100** to the individual control. That is, the server **200** excludes vehicles **100** at the predicted parts P1 and P2 from a group of the group control. In the predicted parts P1 and P2, it is predicted that there will be a disturbance in the inter-vehicle distance.

Therefore, the server **200** switches the control mode of the vehicles to the individual control.

Accordingly, it is possible to prevent the platoon from being disturbed in advance. Further, at a timing when vehicles **100** pass through the predicted parts P1 and P2, the control mode of these vehicles **100** may be switched to the group control again. At a timing when the vehicles **100** have passed through the predicted parts P1 and P2, the server **200** performs processing for allowing these vehicles **100** which have been subjected to individual control to be grouped again.

Second Embodiment

[0097] In a second embodiment, a vehicle manufacturing system **50** switches a control mode in accordance with a communication status. In a case where the communication status is good, the vehicle manufacturing system **50** performs an individual control. In a case where the communication status is not good, the vehicle manufacturing system **50** switches the control mode to a group control. Specifically, in a case where a communication band is tightened or a case where a communication speed is decreased, the vehicle manufacturing system **50** performs a group control in order to reduce a communication load. In a case where the communication band is not tightened or a case where the communication speed is not decreased, the vehicle manufacturing system **50** performs an individual control. In the individual control, a control instruction value for controlling a speed or a route (direction) of a vehicle is individually computed and transmitted. In the group control, a common control instruction value for controlling a speed or a route of the plurality of vehicles is computed and transmitted.

[0098] With reference to FIG. 5, a vehicle manufacturing system and a vehicle manufacturing method according to the second embodiment will be described. FIG. 5 is a block diagram showing a control system of the vehicle manufacturing system **50**. Since the basic configuration of the vehicle manufacturing system **50** and a method for controlling the same are similar to those in the first embodiment, the description thereof will be omitted as appropriate. For example, the position calculation unit **252**, the vehicle **100**, the sensor **300**, the computing unit **253**, the address granting unit **256**, the address management unit **257**, and the like have configurations similar to those in the

first embodiment.

[0099] The server **200** includes a communication status determination unit **258** and a control switch unit **259**. That is, the communication status determination unit **258** and the control switch unit **259** are added to the server **200**.

[0100] The communication status determination unit **258** determines the communication status in the system **50**. The communication status determination unit **258** determines whether the communication status is good or poor in accordance with a communication speed in a manufacturing factory. The communication status determination unit **258** outputs a result of the determination to the control switch unit **259**.

[0101] The control switch unit **259** switches the individual control and the group control in accordance with a result of determining the communication status. The control switch unit **259** switches control of the computing unit **253** and the control of the transmitter **232** in accordance with a result of determining the communication status. In a case where the communication status is good, the control switch unit **259** controls the computing unit **253** and the transmitter **232** in such a way that the individual control will be performed. The computing unit **253** computes individual control instruction values for the respective vehicles, and the transmitter **232** transmits the individual control instruction values. Accordingly, it is possible to individually control at least one of the speed or the route of the vehicle **100**.

[0102] In a case where the communication status is poor, the control switch unit **259** switches the control mode to the group control. The computing unit **253** computes a common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles **100**. The communication apparatus **230** transmits the common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles **100**. Accordingly, it is possible to prevent the processing load and the communication load from increasing. Accordingly, a control instruction value of at least one of the speed or the route of the vehicle **100** becomes common among the plurality of vehicles **100**.

[0103] In a case where the communication status is good, the control switch unit **259** switches the control mode to the individual control. The computing unit **253** computes individual control instruction values for the respective vehicles **100**. The communication apparatus **230** transmits the individual control instructions to the respective vehicles **100**. Accordingly, it is possible to move each of the vehicles **100** at different speeds or along different routes. Accordingly, it is possible to control traveling of the vehicles **100** with a higher accuracy and to perform control in accordance with the latest status of the vehicle manufacturing system **50**.

[0104] Specifically, the communication status determination unit **258** measures a communication delay time (latency) or a radio wave strength and compares the measured value with a threshold. The communication status determination unit **258** then determines whether or not the communication status is good in accordance with a result of comparing the measured value with the threshold.

[0105] For example, the communication status determination unit **258** measures a communication response time using a ping command. In a case where the response time is longer than the threshold, that is, in a case where the latency is high, the communication status determination unit **258** determines that the communication status is poor. In a case where the response time is shorter than the threshold, that is, in a case where the latency is low, the communication status determination unit **258** determines that the communication status is good. In a case where the latency is low, the control switch unit **259** switches the control mode to the group control.

[0106] Alternatively, a communication channel occupancy rate is measured based on a radio wave strength of a radio communication signal. In a case where the channel occupancy rate is higher than a threshold, a communication band is tightened, in which case the control switch unit **259** switches the group control to the individual control. In a case where the channel occupancy rate is lower than the threshold, a communication band is not tightened, in which case the control switch unit **259** switches the control mode to the group control.

[0107] As described above, the control switch unit **259** switches the control of the position calculation unit **252** and the control of the transmitter **232** in accordance with a result of determining the communication status in such a way that individual control instruction values are computed for respective vehicles and transmitted to the respective vehicles. As a matter of course, data used to determine the communication status is not limited to a channel occupancy rate or a delay time. Further, the communication status determination unit **258** may determine the communication status based on two or more kinds of data.

[0108] If the number of vehicles **100** to be controlled increases, it is possible that the communication band may be tightened and the vehicles **100** may not be able to receive control instruction values at appropriate timings. In this case, the server **200** switches the control mode to the group control in order to prevent the communication load from increasing. That is, the server **200** computes a common control instruction value for a plurality of vehicles **100** and transmits the common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles **100**. Accordingly, it is possible to prevent the processing load and the communication load from increasing.

[0109] Further, the control switch unit **259** may control the computing unit **253** so as to switch the speed of the vehicle **100** in accordance with the communication status. For example, the control switch unit **259** switches the control mode so as to reduce the vehicle speed in a case where the communication status is poor. Therefore, the vehicle speed when the communication status is not good becomes lower than the vehicle speed when the communication status is good. In a case where the communication status is poor, the computing unit **253** computes the control instruction values in such a way that vehicles **100** included in the group of the group control can travel at a low speed. The vehicle speed of the vehicles **100** in the group control or the individual control may be determined in accordance with the inter-vehicle distances or the like.

[0110] Further, in the aforementioned description, in a case where the communication status is poor, the system **50** may change only the speed without switching the individual control to the group control. That is, in a case where it is determined that the communication status is poor, the system **50** may reduce the speed of each vehicle **100** by individual control instruction values.

[0111] In the group control, the server **200** cannot transmit control instruction values indicating vehicle speeds to the respective vehicles **100**. Therefore, it is difficult to perform control to change the inter-vehicle distances. The server **200** performs control in such a way that the vehicle **100** moves at a low speed, whereby it is possible to increase the time for the vehicle **100** to travel the inter-vehicle distance (inter-vehicle time). That is, the inter-vehicle time can be secured, whereby it is possible to improve safety.

[0112] In a case where the group control is performed and a vehicle **100** reaches a place where it is expected that the platoon will be disturbed, the control mode of this vehicle **100** may be switched from the group control to the individual control. The processes in the first embodiment and the processes in the second embodiment may be performed in combination with each other. That is, the control switch unit **259** may switch the individual control and the group control based on one or both of the inter-vehicle distance and the communication status. Accordingly, the individual control and the group control can be switched at appropriate timings.

[0113] FIG. **6** is a flowchart showing a vehicle manufacturing method according to this embodiment. First, the server **200** sets an IP address for unicast and an IP address for multicast for each vehicle **100** in advance (S21). The computing unit **253** computes individual control instruction values for performing an individual control (S22). The transmitter **232** individually transmits the control instruction values to the respective IP addresses for unicast (S23). Since these processes are similar to Steps S11, S17, and S18 in FIG. **4**, the detailed descriptions thereof will be omitted.

[0114] Next, the communication status determination unit **258** determines the communication status (S24). For example, the communication status determination unit **258** determines whether or not the communication status is good in accordance with a radio wave strength or a communication speed. As described above, the communication status determination unit **258** compares a channel

occupancy rate or a delay time with a threshold to thereby determine whether or not the communication status is good.

[0115] In a case where the communication status is good (“good” in S24), the control switch unit **259** switches the control mode to an individual control, in which case the computing unit **253** computes individual control instruction values for a plurality of respective vehicles **100** (S25). Then the transmitter **232** individually transmits the control instruction values to the respective IP addresses for unicast (S26). Since the above processes are similar to Steps S17 and S18 in FIG. 4, the detailed descriptions will be omitted.

[0116] In a case where the communication status is not good (“poor” in S24), the control switch unit **259** switches the control mode to a group control, in which case the computing unit **253** computes a common control instruction value for the plurality of vehicles **100** (S27). The transmitter **232** transmits the control instruction value to the IP addresses for multicast (S28). Since these processes are similar to those in Steps S15 and S16 in FIG. 4, the detailed descriptions thereof will be omitted. Further, in Step S27, the position calculation unit **252** may obtain a control instruction value in such a way that the vehicle speed becomes lower than those indicated by the control instruction values computed in Steps S25 and S22.

[0117] The server **200** determines whether or not the processing has ended (S29). In a case where the processing has not ended (NO in S29), the process returns to Step S24, where the vehicle manufacturing system **50** repeats processing. In a case where the processing has ended (YES in S29), the vehicle manufacturing system **50** ends the processing.

[0118] As described above, in a case where the communication status has degraded, the control switch unit **259** switches the individual control to the group control. Accordingly, it is possible to reduce the communication load and suppress the communication delay of the control instruction values. In the first and second embodiments, the example in which vehicles that perform platoon traveling are controlled during a manufacturing process in a factory has been described. However, the above-described system and method may also be applied to control performed in a case where vehicles after being manufactured perform platoon traveling. For example, the above-described system and method may control vehicles **100** in a transporting process such as transportation to a yard or shipment.

[0119] Hereinafter, travel control examples for controlling traveling of the vehicle **100** in a system will be explained.

A. Travel Control Example 1

[0120] FIG. 7 is a conceptual diagram showing a configuration of a system **50** according to a travel control example 1. The system **50** includes a plurality of vehicles **100**, each of which corresponds to a mobile body, a server **200**, and one or more sensors **300**.

[0121] Note that, when the mobile body is other than a vehicle, the terms “vehicle” and “car” in the present disclosure can be replaced by a “mobile body” as appropriate, and the term “travel” can be replaced by “move” as appropriate.

[0122] The vehicle **100** is configured to be able to travel by unmanned driving. The “unmanned driving” means driving not dependent on a driver's traveling operation. The traveling operation means an operation regarding at least one of “run”, “turn”, or “stop” of the vehicle **100**. The unmanned driving is achieved by automatic or manual remote control that uses an apparatus located in the outside of the vehicle **100**, or by autonomous control of the vehicle **100**. Any passenger who does not perform the traveling operation may get on the vehicle **100** traveled by unmanned driving. The passenger who does not perform the traveling operation includes, for example, a person who is just sitting on a seat of the vehicle **100**, and a person who is performing work such as an operation of assembling, an operation of inspection, or an operation of switches, which is an operation other than the traveling operation, while getting in the vehicle **100**. Note that the driving by the traveling operation of the driver may be referred to as “manned driving”.

[0123] The “remote control” here includes “complete remote control” in which all the operations of

the vehicle **100** are completely determined from the outside of the vehicle **100** and “partial remote control” in which a part of the operations of the vehicle **100** is determined from the outside of the vehicle **100**. Further, “autonomous control” includes “complete autonomous control” in which the vehicle **100** autonomously controls its own operation without receiving any piece of information from an external apparatus outside the vehicle **100** and “partial autonomous control” in which the vehicle **100** autonomously controls its own operation using information received from the external apparatus outside the vehicle **100**.

[0124] In this embodiment, the system **50** is used in a factory FC which manufactures the vehicles **100**. The reference coordinate system of the factory FC is a global coordinate system GC. That is, a desired position in the factory FC is expressed by coordinates of X, Y, and Z in the global coordinate system GC. The factory FC includes a first place PL1 and a second place PL2. The first place PL1 and the second place PL2 are connected to each other by a traveling path TR along which the vehicle **100** can travel. A plurality of sensors **300** are installed along the traveling path TR in the factory FC. The positions of the respective sensors **300** in the factory FC are adjusted in advance. The vehicle **100** moves from the first place PL1 to the second place PL2 along the traveling path TR by unmanned driving.

[0125] FIG. **8** is a block diagram showing a configuration of the system **50**. The vehicle **100** includes a vehicle control apparatus **110** for controlling each part of the vehicle **100**, actuators **120** including one or more actuators that drive under a control of the vehicle control apparatus **110**, and a communication apparatus **130** for communicating with an external apparatus such as the server **200** by wireless communication. The actuators **120** include an actuator of a drive apparatus for accelerating the vehicle **100**, an actuator of a steering apparatus for changing a traveling direction of the vehicle **100**, and an actuator of a control apparatus for decelerating the vehicle **100**.

[0126] The vehicle control apparatus **110** is composed of a computer including a processor **111**, a memory **112**, an input/output interface **113**, and an internal bus **114**. The processor **111**, the memory **112**, and the input/output interface **113** are connected to one another via the internal bus **114** in such a way that they can communicate with one another. The actuators **120** and the communication apparatus **130** are connected to the input/output interface **113**. The processor **111** executes a program PG1 stored in the memory **112**, thereby implementing various functions including a function as a vehicle control unit **115**.

[0127] The vehicle control unit **115** causes the vehicle **100** to travel by controlling the actuators **120**. The vehicle control unit **115** is able to cause the vehicle **100** to travel by controlling the actuators **120** using a travel control signal received from the server **200**. The travel control signal is a control signal for traveling the vehicle **100**. In this embodiment, the travel control signal includes an acceleration and a steering angle of the vehicle **100** as parameters. In another embodiment, the travel control signal may include, in place of or in addition to the acceleration of the vehicle **100**, a speed of the vehicle **100** as a parameter.

[0128] The server **200** is composed of a computer including a processor **201**, a memory **202**, an input/output interface **203**, and an internal bus **204**. The processor **201**, the memory **202**, and the input/output interface **203** are connected to one another via the internal bus **204** in such a way that they can communicate with one another. A communication apparatus **205** for communicating with various kinds of apparatuses provided outside the server **200** is connected to the input/output interface **203**. The communication apparatus **205** can communicate with the vehicle **100** by wireless communication and can communicate with each of the sensors **300** by wired communication or wireless communication. The processor **201** executes a program PG2 stored in the memory **202**, thereby implementing various functions including the function as a remote control unit **210**.

[0129] The remote control unit **210** acquires a result of detection by the sensors, generates a travel control signal for controlling the actuators **120** of the vehicle **100** using the result of the detection, and transmits the travel control signal to the vehicle **100**, thereby causing the vehicle **100** to travel

by remote control. The remote control unit **210** may generate not only the travel control signal but also, for example, control signals for controlling actuators for operating various kinds of auxiliary equipment provided in the vehicle **100** or various kinds of equipment such as a windshield wiper, power windows, or lamps. That is, the remote control unit **210** may operate these various kinds of equipment or various kinds of auxiliary equipment by remote control.

[0130] The sensor **300** is a sensor that is provided outside the vehicle **100**. The sensor **300** according to this embodiment is a sensor that captures the vehicle **100** from the outside of the vehicle **100**. The sensor **300** includes a communication apparatus (not shown) and can communicate with other apparatuses such as the server **200** and so on by wired communication or wireless communication. Specifically, the sensor **300** is composed of a camera. The camera as the sensor **300** captures an image including the vehicle **100**, and outputs the captured image as a result of detection.

[0131] FIG. **9** is a flowchart showing a processing procedure of travel control of the vehicle **100** according to the travel control example. In the processing procedure shown in FIG. **9**, the processor **201** of the server **200** functions as the remote control unit **210** by executing the program PG2. Further, the processor **111** of the vehicle **100** functions as the vehicle control unit **115** by executing the program PG1.

[0132] In Step S110, the processor **201** of the server **200** acquires vehicle position information of the vehicle **100** using the result of the detection output from the sensor **300**. The vehicle position information is position information that forms a basis for generating a travel control signal. In this embodiment, the vehicle position information includes the position and the orientation of the vehicle **100** in a global coordinate system GC of the factory FC. Specifically, in Step S110, the processor **201** acquires the vehicle position information using the captured image acquired from the camera, which is the sensor **300**.

[0133] Specifically, in Step S110, the processor **201** detects, for example, the outline of the vehicle **100** from the captured image, calculates the coordinate system of the captured image, that is, coordinates of measurement points of the vehicle **100** in the local coordinate system, and converts the calculated coordinates into coordinates in a global coordinate system GC, thereby acquiring the position of the vehicle **100**. The outline of the vehicle **100** included in the captured image can be detected, for example, by inputting the captured image to the detection model DM that uses artificial intelligence. The detection model DM is prepared, for example, in the system **50** or in the outside of the system **50** and is stored in the memory **202** of the server **200** in advance. The detection model DM may be, for example, a learned machine learning model learned so as to implement one of semantic segmentation or instance segmentation. This machine learning model may be, for example, convolutional neural network (hereinafter, CNN) learned by supervised learning using a learning dataset. The learning dataset includes, for example, a plurality of training images including the vehicle **100**, and a label indicating whether each area in the training image is an area indicating the vehicle **100** or an area indicating a part other than the vehicle **100**. When CNN learning is performed, parameters of the CNN are preferably updated in such a way that the error between the result of the output by the detection model DM and the label is reduced by a back propagation method. Further, the processor **201** is able to acquire the orientation of the vehicle **100** by estimating it based on the direction of the moving vector of the vehicle **100** calculated from changes in positions of feature points of the vehicle **100** between frames of the captured image using an optical flow method.

[0134] In Step S120, the processor **201** of the server **200** determines the target position that the vehicle **100** should go next. In this embodiment, the target position is expressed by coordinates of X, Y, and Z in a global coordinate system GC. The memory **202** of the server **200** stores a reference route RR, which is a route along which the vehicle **100** should travel, in advance. The route is expressed by a node indicating the departure place, nodes indicating passage points, a node that indicates the target position, and a link connecting the respective nodes. The processor **201**

determines the target position that the vehicle **100** should go next using the vehicle position information and the reference route RR. The processor **201** determines the target position on the reference route RR which is ahead of the current position of the vehicle **100**.

[0135] In Step S130, the processor **201** of the server **200** generates a travel control signal for traveling the vehicle **100** toward the determined target position. The processor **201** calculates the traveling speed of the vehicle **100** from the transition of the position of the vehicle **100** and compares the calculated traveling speed with the target speed. In general, when the traveling speed is lower than the target speed, the processor **201** determines the acceleration in such a way that the vehicle **100** accelerates. On the other hand, when the traveling speed is higher than the target speed, the processor **201** determines the acceleration in such a way that the vehicle **100** decelerates. Further, when the vehicle **100** is positioned on the reference route RR, the processor **201** determines the steering angle and the acceleration to prevent the vehicle **100** from being deviated from the reference route RR. On the other hand, when the vehicle **100** is not positioned on the reference route RR, that is, when the vehicle **100** is deviated from the reference route RR, the processor **201** determines the steering angle and the acceleration in such a way that the vehicle **100** returns onto the reference route RR.

[0136] In Step S140, the processor **201** of the server **200** transmits a generated travel control signal to the vehicle **100**. The processor **201** repeats, in a predetermined cycle, acquisition of the position of the vehicle **100**, determination of the target position, generation of the travel control signal, transmission of the travel control signal, and the like.

[0137] In Step S150, the processor **111** of the vehicle **100** receives the travel control signal transmitted from the server **200**. In Step S160, the processor **111** of the vehicle **100** controls the actuators **120** using the received travel control signal, thereby causing the vehicle **100** to travel at an acceleration and a steering angle indicated in the travel control signal. The processor **111** repeats reception of the travel control signal, and control of the actuators **120** in a predetermined cycle. With the system **50** in this example, it is possible to cause the vehicle **100** to travel by remote control and to move the vehicle **100** without using transport equipment such as cranes or conveyors.

B: Travel Control Example 2

[0138] FIG. **10** is an explanatory diagram showing a schematic configuration of a system **50v** according to a travel control example 2. In this example, the system **50v** is different from that in the travel control example 1 in that the system **50v** does not include the server **200**. Further, a vehicle **100v** in this configuration can travel by autonomous control of the vehicle **100v**. The other configurations are the same as those stated above unless otherwise specified.

[0139] In this example, a processor **111v** of a vehicle control apparatus **110v** functions as a vehicle control unit **115v** by executing a program PG1 stored in a memory **112v**. The vehicle control unit **115v** acquires a result of output by a sensor, generates a travel control signal using the result of the output, and outputs the generated travel control signal to operate the actuators **120**, thereby enabling the vehicle **100v** to travel by autonomous control. In this example, the memory **112v** stores, besides the program PG1, a detection model DM and a reference route RR in advance.

[0140] FIG. **11** is a flowchart showing a processing procedure of a travel control of the vehicle **100v** in Travel control Example 2. In the processing procedure shown in FIG. **11**, the processor **111v** of the vehicle **100v** functions as the vehicle control unit **115v** by executing the program PG1.

[0141] In Step S210, the processor **111v** of the vehicle control apparatus **110v** acquires vehicle position information using a result of detection output from a camera, which is the sensor **300**. In Step S220, the processor **111v** determines the target position that the vehicle **100v** should go next. In Step S230, the processor **111v** generates a travel control signal for causing the vehicle **100v** to travel toward the determined target position. In Step S240, the processor **111v** controls the actuators **120** using the generated travel control signal, thereby causing the vehicle **100v** to travel according to a parameter indicated in the travel control signal. The processor **111v** repeats acquisition of the

vehicle position information, determination of the target position, generation of the travel control signal, and control of the actuators in a predetermined cycle. With the system **50v** in this example, it is possible to cause the vehicle **100v** to travel by autonomous control of the vehicle **100v** without remotely controlling the vehicle **100v** by the server **200**.

YY: Other Travel Control Examples

[0142] (YY1) In the above examples, the sensor **300** is a camera. On the other hand, the sensor **300** may not be a camera, and may instead be, for example, Light Detection And Ranging (LiDAR). In this case, the result of the detection output from the sensor **300** may be three dimensional point cloud data indicating the vehicle **100**. In this case, the server **200** and the vehicle **100** may acquire the vehicle position information by template matching that uses three dimensional point cloud data indicating the result of the detection and reference point cloud data that is prepared in advance.

[0143] (YY2) In the travel control example 1, the server **200** executes processing from the acquisition of the vehicle position information to the generation of the travel control signal. On the other hand, the vehicle **100** may perform at least a part of the processing from the acquisition of the vehicle position information to the generation of the travel control signal. For example, the following forms from (1) to (3) may be employed. [0144] (1) The server **200** may acquire vehicle position information, determine the target position that the vehicle **100** should go next, and generate a route from the current position of the vehicle **100** indicated in the acquired vehicle position information to the target position. The server **200** may generate a route to a target position which is between the current position and the target position or may generate a route to the target position. The server **200** may transmit the generated route to the vehicle **100**. The vehicle **100** may generate the travel control signal in such a way that the vehicle **100** travels along the route received from the server **200** and control the actuators **120** using the generated travel control signal. [0145]

(2) The server **200** may acquire vehicle position information and transmit the acquired vehicle position information to the vehicle **100**. The vehicle **100** may determine the target position that the vehicle **100** should go next, generate a route from the current position of the vehicle **100** indicated in the received vehicle position information to the target position, generate a travel control signal in such a way that the vehicle **100** travels along the generated route, and control the actuators **120** using the generated travel control signal. [0146] (3) In the forms of the above (1) and (2), an internal sensor may be mounted on the vehicle **100**, and a result of detection output from the internal sensor may be used in at least one of the generation of the route or the generation of the travel control signal. The internal sensor is a sensor mounted on the vehicle **100**. The internal sensor may include, for example, a sensor that detects a motion state of the vehicle **100**, a sensor that detects an operation state of each part of the vehicle **100**, and a sensor that detects an environment near the vehicle **100**. Specifically, the internal sensor may include, for example, a camera, LiDAR, a millimeter wave radar, an ultrasonic sensor, a GPS sensor, an acceleration sensor, a gyro sensor or the like. For example, in the form of the above (1), the server **200** may acquire the result of the detection in the internal sensor and reflect the result of the detection in the internal sensor in the route when the route is generated. In the form of the above (1), the vehicle **100** may acquire the result of the detection in the internal sensor and reflect the result of the detection in the internal sensor in a travel control signal when the travel control signal is generated. In the form of the above (2), the vehicle **100** may acquire the result of the detection in the internal sensor, and reflect the result of the detection in the internal sensor in the route when the route is generated. In the form of the above (2), the vehicle **100** may acquire the result of the detection in the internal sensor, and reflect the result of the detection in the internal sensor in the travel control signal when the travel control signal is generated.

[0147] (YY3) In the travel control example 2, an internal sensor may be mounted on the vehicle **100v** and the result of the detection output from the internal sensor may be used in at least one of the generation of the route or the generation of the travel control signal. For example, the vehicle **100v** may acquire the result of the detection in the internal sensor, and reflect the result of the

detection in the internal sensor in the route when the route is generated. The vehicle **100v** may acquire the result of the detection in the internal sensor and reflect the result of the detection in the internal sensor in the travel control signal when the travel control signal is generated.

[0148] (YY4) In the travel control example 2, the vehicle **100v** acquires the vehicle position information using the result of the detection by the sensor **300**. On the other hand, an internal sensor is mounted on the vehicle **100v**, and the vehicle **100v** may acquire vehicle position information using a result of detection in the internal sensor, determine the target position that the vehicle **100v** should go next, generate a route from the current position of the vehicle **100v** indicated in the acquired vehicle position information to the target position, generate a travel control signal for traveling along the generated route, and control the actuators **120** using the generated travel control signal. In this case, the vehicle **100v** may travel without using the result of the detection by the sensor **300**. Note that the vehicle **100v** may acquire a target arrival time or congestion information from the outside of the vehicle **100v** and reflect the target arrival time or the congestion information in at least one of the route or the travel control signal. Further, all the functional configurations of the system **50v** may be provided in the vehicle **100v**. That is, the processing implemented by the system **50v** in the present disclosure may be achieved by the vehicle **100v** alone. For example, a leading vehicle **100v** may transmit control instruction values to the following vehicle **100**.

[0149] (YY5) In the travel control example 1, the server **200** automatically generates a travel control signal to be transmitted to the vehicle **100**. On the other hand, the server **200** may generate the travel control signal to be transmitted to the vehicle **100** in accordance with an operation performed by an external operator located in the outside of the vehicle **100**. For example, the external operator may operate a manipulation apparatus including a display for displaying a captured image output from the sensor **300**, a steering, an accelerator pedal, and a brake pedal for remotely operating the vehicle **100**, and a communication apparatus for communicating with the server **200** by wired communication or wireless communication, and the server **200** may generate a travel control signal in accordance with the operation added to the manipulation apparatus.

[0150] (YY6) In each of the above travel control examples, it is sufficient that the vehicle **100** include a configuration capable of moving by unmanned driving, and the vehicle **100** may have, for example, a form of a platform including the configurations stated below. Specifically, it is sufficient that the vehicle **100** at least include the vehicle control apparatus **110** and the actuators **120** in order to exert three functions of “run”, “turn”, and “stop” by unmanned driving. In a case where the vehicle **100** externally acquires information for unmanned driving, the vehicle **100** may further include a communication apparatus **130**. That is, the vehicle **100** that can move by unmanned driving may not be provided with at least some of internal components such as a driving seat or a dashboard, at least some of the external components such as a bumper or a fender, or a body shell. In this case, before the vehicle **100** is shipped from the factory FC, the other components such as a body shell may be mounted on the vehicle **100**, or the other components such as the body shell may be mounted on the vehicle **100** after the vehicle **100** is shipped from the factory FC in a state in which the other components such as the body shell are not mounted on the vehicle **100**. Each of the components may be mounted thereon from a desired direction such as an upper side, a lower side, a front side, a rear side, a right side, or a left side of the vehicle **100**, mounted thereon from the same direction, or mounted thereon from different directions. In terms of the form of the platform, the position may be determined as in the vehicle **100** according to the first embodiment.

[0151] (YY7) The vehicle **100** may be manufactured by combining a plurality of modules. The module means a unit formed of a plurality of components grouped according to a part or a function of the vehicle **100**. For example, the platform of the vehicle **100** may be manufactured by combining a front module that forms a front part of the platform, a central module that forms a central part of the platform, and a rear module that forms a rear part of the platform with one another. Note that the number of modules that form the platform is not limited to three, and may be

two or smaller or four or larger. Further, in addition to or in place of the components that form the platform, components of the vehicle **100** that form parts other than the platform may be formed in modules. Further, these modules may include any exterior components such as a bumper or a grill or any interior components such as seats and a console. Further, not only the vehicle **100** but also any form of mobile body may be manufactured by combining a plurality of modules. These modules may be manufactured, for example, by joining a plurality of components by welding, fixtures, or the like, or may be manufactured by integrally molding at least some of the components that form the module as one component by casting. A molding method of integrally forming one component, in particular, a relatively large-sized component is also called gigacasting or megacasting. For example, the above front module, central module, and rear module may be manufactured using gigacasting.

[0152] (YY8) Transporting a vehicle **100** using traveling of the vehicle **100** by unmanned driving is also referred to as “self-propelled transportation”. Further, a configuration for achieving self-propelled transportation is referred to as a “vehicle remote control autonomous travel transportation system”. Further, a production method for producing vehicles **100** using self-propelled transportation is also referred to as “self-propelled production”. In the self-propelled production, for example, in a factory FC that manufactures the vehicles **100**, a part of the transportation of the vehicle **100** is achieved by self-propelled transportation.

[0153] (YY9) In each of the above travel control examples, some or all of the functions and processing implemented in the form of software may be implemented in the form of hardware. Further, some or all of the functions and processing implemented in the form of hardware may be implemented in the form of software. For example, various types of circuits such as an integrated circuit or a discrete circuit may be used as hardware for implementing various types of functions in each of the above embodiments.

[0154] Further, some or all of the processing performed in the vehicle **100**, the server **200**, the sensor **300**, the robot **600**, and so on described above may be implemented as a computer program.

[0155] A (The) program can be stored and provided to a computer using any type of non-transitory computer readable media. Non-transitory computer readable media include any type of tangible storage media. Examples of non-transitory computer readable media include magnetic storage media (such as floppy disks, magnetic tapes, hard disk drives, etc.), optical magnetic storage media (e.g. magneto-optical disks), CD-ROM (compact disc read only memory), CD-R (compact disc recordable), CD-R/W (compact disc rewritable), and semiconductor memories (such as mask ROM, PROM (programmable ROM), EPROM (erasable PROM), flash ROM, RAM (random access memory), etc.). The program may be provided to a computer using any type of transitory computer readable media. Examples of transitory computer readable media include electric signals, optical signals, and electromagnetic waves. Transitory computer readable media can provide the program to a computer via a wired communication line (e.g. electric wires, and optical fibers) or a wireless communication line.

[0156] From the disclosure thus described, it will be obvious that the embodiments of the disclosure may be varied in many ways. Such variations are not to be regarded as a departure from the spirit and scope of the disclosure, and all such modifications as would be obvious to one skilled in the art are intended for inclusion within the scope of the following claims.

Claims

1. A vehicle manufacturing system for performing control in such a way that a plurality of vehicles forming a platoon travel during a manufacturing process or a transporting process, the vehicle manufacturing system comprising: a computation unit for computing a control instruction value for controlling a speed of the vehicle; a sensor provided to detect an inter-vehicle distance, which is a distance between one of the plurality of vehicles and another adjacent one of the plurality of

vehicles; a determination unit for determining, based on the inter-vehicle distance, whether or not the platoon is disturbed; a transmitter configured to transmit, in a case where the platoon is not disturbed, a common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles; a communication apparatus that is provided in the vehicle and receives the control instruction value; and speed control unit for controlling the speed of the vehicle in accordance with the control instruction value.

2. The vehicle manufacturing system according to claim 1, wherein the transmitter transmits, in a case where the platoon is disturbed, individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles.
3. The vehicle manufacturing system according to claim 2, further comprising an address granting unit for granting, in a case where the platoon is not disturbed, a common address to the communication apparatus of each of the plurality of vehicles, and granting, in a case where the platoon is disturbed, individual addresses to the communication apparatuses of the plurality of respective vehicles.
4. The vehicle manufacturing system according to claim 1, wherein the transmitter transmits an individual control instruction value to the vehicle that has reached a predicted part where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary.
5. The vehicle manufacturing system according to claim 1, comprising a camera configured to capture an image of any one of the vehicles in the platoon, wherein the computation unit computes the control instruction value based on a result of capturing the image in the camera.
6. The vehicle manufacturing system according to claim 1, wherein the control instruction value includes a value indicating a speed or an acceleration of the vehicle.
7. A vehicle manufacturing method for performing control in such a way that a plurality of vehicles forming a platoon travel during a manufacturing process or a transporting process, the method comprising: computing a control instruction value for controlling a speed of the vehicle; detecting, based on a result of detection in a sensor, an inter-vehicle distance, which is a distance between one of the plurality of vehicles and another adjacent one of the plurality of vehicles; determining, based on the inter-vehicle distance, whether or not the platoon is disturbed; transmitting by a transmitter, when the platoon is not disturbed, a common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles; receiving the control instruction value by a communication apparatus provided in the vehicle; and controlling the speed of the vehicle in accordance with the control instruction value.
8. The vehicle manufacturing method according to claim 7, wherein the transmitter transmits, in a case where the platoon is disturbed, individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles.
9. The vehicle manufacturing method according to claim 7, further comprising an address granting unit for granting, in a case where the platoon is not disturbed, a common address to the communication apparatus of each of the plurality of vehicles, and granting, in a case where the platoon is disturbed, individual addresses to the communication apparatuses of the plurality of respective vehicles.
10. The vehicle manufacturing method according to claim 7, wherein the transmitter transmits an individual control instruction value to the vehicle that has reached a predicted part where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary.
11. The vehicle manufacturing method according to claim 7, comprising: capturing, by a camera, an image of any one of the vehicles in the platoon; and computing the control instruction value based on a result of capturing the image in the camera.
12. The vehicle manufacturing method according to claim 7, wherein the control instruction value includes a value indicating a speed or an acceleration of the vehicle.
13. A vehicle manufacturing system for performing control in such a way that a plurality of vehicles forming a platoon travel during a manufacturing process or a transporting process, the vehicle manufacturing system comprising: a computation unit for computing individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles in order to control at least one of a speed or a route of the vehicle; a transmitter configured to transmit the individual control instruction values to the respective vehicles; a communication apparatus that is provided in the vehicle and receives the

control instruction value; and a control unit for controlling traveling of the vehicle in accordance with the control instruction value; a communication status determination unit for determining a communication status; and a control switching unit for switching control of the computation unit and control of the transmitter in accordance with a result of determining the communication status in such a way that the computation unit computes a common control instruction value for the plurality of vehicles and the transmitter transmits the common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles.

14. The vehicle manufacturing system according to claim 13, wherein in a case where the communication status determination unit determines that the communication status is poor, the control switching unit switches control of the computation unit and control of the transmitter in accordance with a result of determining the communication status in such a way that the computation unit computes a common control instruction value for the plurality of vehicles and the transmitter transmits the common control instruction value to the plurality of vehicles.

15. The vehicle manufacturing system according to claim 13, wherein in a case where the communication status determination unit determines that the communication status is poor, the computation unit computes the control instruction value so as to decrease the speed of the vehicle.

16. The vehicle manufacturing system according to claim 13, wherein the transmitter transmits an individual control instruction value to the vehicle that has reached a predicted part where it is expected that the inter-vehicle distances will vary.
